One of the finest surviving examples of tenth-century Chola copper alloy casting in its first phase is now in the Freer Gallery of Art in Washington (see page 243). This metre-high statuette of the goddess Parvati was installed during the queen's lifetime and under her aegis in the Shiva temple of Kailasanatha Svamin, a relatively modest temple that she herself built in a new village named after her near Nagapattinam – perhaps no coincidence, since Nagapattinam was already the centre of a copper alloy casting industry dedicated to producing Buddhist images. This particular statuette would originally have stood alongside her partner Lord Shiva as well as other images of the temple's *Sapta Maadhaka* – the seven goddesses Brahmi, Maheshwari, Cowmaari, Vaishnavi, Varahi, Indrani and Chamundi – all of them subsequently buried for their protection and then lost for centuries in a pattern repeated many times over at other Chola temples.

One of the recovered images was the Parvati bronze. Some inspired detective work by the distinguished art historian Vidya Dehejia has all but proved that this exquisite work of art, acquired by an American collector back in the 1920s in somewhat shadowy circumstances, is nothing less than a representation of the great queen Sembiyan Mahadevi herself, albeit in the form of Lord Shiva's consort Parvati. Stylised rather than natural, wasp-waisted with unmistakably sensuous hips swaying in the stance known as *tribhanga* or 'triple-bent', the figure's face shows some individual features but is sufficiently mannered to be taken for a goddess, so blurring the lines between what was royal and what was divine. Her elongated left hand is lowered by her side with fingers pointing downward in the *varada mudra*, a gesture that signifies a promise to grant the devotee's wishes. Her right hand is raised in order to grasp a (now missing) flower, most probably a lotus or blue lily.